Submission to the Joint Standing Committee on Electoral Matters – Inquiry into the 2025 Federal Election

With Supporting Statements from:

• Heather Reid, Bunbury WA

• Lachlan MacAlister, Eaton WA

• [redacted], Dalyellup WA

Introduction

Thank you for the opportunity to provide feedback regarding the conduct of campaign volunteers and campaign behaviour during the 2025 federal election in the electorate of Forrest. This submission intends to highlight issues that impacted the sense of fairness, respect, and safety within the democratic process, and to suggest constructive improvements to the training and expectations placed on campaign teams and volunteers.

The observations provided relate to the Bunbury Sea Scouts pre-poll centre, Glen Huon Primary School, Dalyellup College, and multiple public billboards across Bunbury and the South West.

1. Statement from Heather Reid – Bunbury Sea Scouts (Pre-Poll)

Heather Reid volunteered in support of the "Keep the Sheep" campaign, a lawful advocacy effort concerning agricultural policy and its impact on rural communities. During the day, a volunteer representing the [redacted] candidate, [redacted], approached her and stated that, as a “known [redacted] she “should not be able to” support the Keep the Sheep campaign.

This remark was inappropriate and constituted an attempt to interfere with Heather’s right to advocate on a lawful issue of importance to her community.

Additionally, several volunteers, particularly those representing the [redacted] candidate and the [redacted] appeared unaware of rules regarding respectful engagement, appropriate distance from the entrance, and interactions with other campaigners. The Booth Manager ultimately had to intervene and request volunteers to stop arguing and to behave respectfully towards each other and members of the public.

This situation highlights the need for clearer and more consistent pre-election training for campaign volunteers.

2. Statement from Lachlan MacAlister – Glen Huon Primary School, Eaton

At Glen Huon Primary School, volunteers for the [redacted] candidate, [redacted], repeatedly encouraged undecided voters to use the Build a Ballot tool. This tool is associated with climate activist groups and promotes preference outcomes that are not politically neutral. However, volunteers presented it as an unbiased decision-making tool.

Lachlan raised an alternative option (Vote Compass, which demonstrates a recognised effort toward neutrality). While interactions remained civil, the use of partisan resources presented as objective may mislead voters and indicates a need for standards on transparency when recommending election tools or materials.

3. Statement from [redacted] – Dalyellup College

At Dalyellup College, one [redacted] volunteer placed campaign signage directly in front of existing signage and became aggressive when approached regarding appropriate placement. The issue was resolved only once another [redacted] volunteer advised that their colleague was in the wrong.

Additionally, some aggressive remarks were directed at campaign volunteers by individual [redacted] supporters. While isolated, these incidents reinforce the importance of maintaining respectful behaviour at polling locations.

4. Statement from [redacted] – Offensive Graffiti on Campaign Billboard Signage

During the campaign period, all large-format billboards promoting the [redacted] candidate, [redacted], were vandalised in a coordinated manner across Bunbury and the South West region. The graffiti included the phrase "[redacted]," with the letters i and c replaced by the Chinese character for "big" (大). It is unclear whether this was intended as a linguistic pun, cultural mockery, or a nod to Chinese meme culture or simply an attempt to draw added attention, but the result was vulgar and humiliating in nature.

Additionally, the imagery of [redacted] face was deliberately altered:

• His eyes were blacked out, with large black streaks flowing from them which dehumanised the imagery.

• A small cartoon-like mouse figure was added near his name, seemingly to imply ridicule.

This graffiti was highly visible in public spaces, including on the main walking route used daily by students attending Bunbury Senior High School via the beach path. Young people, families, visitors, and community members were exposed to it repeatedly.

While graffiti on political signage is unfortunately not uncommon during elections, the coordination and vulgarity of this particular instance were concerning. All eight billboards

across the region were vandalised in the same manner, indicating planning rather than spontaneous action.

This incident had a distressing emotional impact on [redacted] family, young volunteers, and many community supporters who saw the messaging as degrading, disrespectful, and well outside the accepted norms of political contest.

This experience highlights the need to reinforce community standards and ensure that electoral participation does not collapse into personal abuse, public shaming, or targeted humiliation.

5. Key Issues Identified Across All Locations and Incidents

1. Lack of consistent understanding of polling place behaviour rules, particularly among new or inexperienced volunteers.

2. Attempts, intentional or otherwise, to discourage lawful advocacy based on perceived political affiliation.

3. Misrepresentation of partisan voting tools as impartial, risking voter misinformation.

4. Escalation of tension and conflict due to poor guidance to volunteers.

5. A concerning breakdown of civility in campaign environments, demonstrated most clearly in the coordinated vandalism of campaign materials.

6. Recommendations

I respectfully request the Committee consider recommending that the Australian Electoral Commission (AEC) strengthen guidance and training for campaign volunteers and campaign organisations, with emphasis on:

• Affirming the right of any individual to advocate for lawful campaigns, regardless of political identity.

• Clear behavioural expectations for volunteers in shared campaign spaces.

• Transparency requirements when recommending digital voting or preference tools.

• Standardised conflict de-escalation training for booth captains and campaign leads.

• A public education reminder that political disagreement must not cross into personal harassment, vandalism, or targeted defamation.

Conclusion

This submission is offered in good faith, with respect for the democratic process and for those who volunteer their time to participate in it. Most volunteers behave responsibly; however, the

incidents described demonstrate a need for clearer training, expectations, and cultural reinforcement of respectful democratic engagement.